

ISS Greenhouse Module

Campaign 1 · Case 01 · Low Earth Orbit



SOLAR  
AGRICULTURAL  
AGENCY

Student Mission

MISSION QUESTION

Why are the lettuce roots tangled and directionless even though water, nutrients, temperature, and lighting appear normal?

SCIENCE FOCUS · GRAVITROPISM IN MICROGRAVITY

Plants normally use gravity to help guide root and shoot growth. In microgravity, that directional cue becomes unreliable, so engineers must provide another way for plants to orient.  
**Science status:** The ISS case story is fictional. Gravitropism, statoliths, and plant responses to environmental cues are real.

REFERENCE

1 · Vocabulary

|              |                                            |              |                                                                   |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gravitropism | Directional growth in response to gravity. | Microgravity | Apparent weightlessness during continuous free fall in orbit.     |
| Statocyte    | Plant cell involved in sensing gravity.    | Statolith    | Dense starch-filled structure that helps provide a direction cue. |
| Phototropism | Directional growth in response to light.   |              |                                                                   |

PREDICTION

2 · Initial thinking

What evidence would help you distinguish a resource problem from an orientation problem?

Name the reading, observation, or record that would help.

# ISS Greenhouse Module

Student Mission · Continued



SOLAR  
AGRICULTURAL  
AGENCY

## EVIDENCE TASK

### 3 · Investigate four evidence sources

Record only evidence that helps support or reject a cause. O = observation/data; I = inference/explanation.

| Source       | Observation or data | What does it support or reject? | O / I |
|--------------|---------------------|---------------------------------|-------|
| Crew         |                     |                                 |       |
| Sensors      |                     |                                 |       |
| Plants       |                     |                                 |       |
| Mission logs |                     |                                 |       |

## ☒ CAUSE TEST

### 4 · Test the competing explanations

| Explanation                          | Status | One evidence-based reason |
|--------------------------------------|--------|---------------------------|
| Nutrient solution is damaging roots. |        |                           |
| The light cycle is wrong.            |        |                           |
| The seed stock is defective.         |        |                           |
| Microgravity disrupts orientation.   |        |                           |

## MECHANISM MODEL

### 5 · Build the mechanism

**WORD BANK** curve or grow without consistent orientation · downward · settle · settle in one direction

#### Earth gravity

Statoliths

→ consistent direction signal

→ roots grow

#### Microgravity

Statoliths do not  consistently

→ unreliable direction signal

→ roots

# ISS Greenhouse Module

Student Mission · Continued



SOLAR  
AGRICULTURAL  
AGENCY

☒ DIAGNOSIS

## 6 · Diagnose and reject an alternative

State the cause in your own words.

Use the environmental condition and the plant mechanism.

Reject the most tempting alternative using evidence.

Name the alternative and the evidence that weakens it.

 EXPLANATION

## 7 · Claim-Evidence-Reasoning

CLAIM

EVIDENCE

REASONING

 ENGINEERING RESPONSE

## 8 · Supply a consistent orientation cue

Choose or design root channels/mesh, a moisture gradient, shoot lighting plus a root guide, a rotating chamber, or another justified design.

Design

One criterion

One constraint

☒ TRANSFER CHECK

## 9 · Exit ticket

Engineers add narrow root channels but do not change the lighting. Which symptom should improve first: tangled roots or pale leaves? Explain.



OPTIONAL EXTENSION

Compare a physical root guide with a rotating growth chamber. Which is easier to use on the ISS, and which more closely replaces gravity?

Student source line: NASA Plant Biology and Plant Gravity Perception resources; NGSS MS-ETS1 Engineering Design.